had governed Punjab during Humayun's first stint on the Hindustani throne, and 'Hakim probably saw control over the Punjab as his birthright'.[3]

Akbar, who had witnessed from the womb what chaos could result from competing fraternal ambitions, who had spent much of his adult life fighting warlords bent on independent rule, who had managed, besides, to create an overarching bureaucracy and philosophy – mansabdari and sulh-i kul, peace for all – to manage a vast empire, from Kabul to Orissa, as if it were one land – this Akbar wasn't going to break the whole thing down just to please his sons. Nor, however, would he simply declare the eldest his heir – Akbar had flouted almost every tradition he inherited, but to break this last custom of his forefathers may have been the line he could not cross. Or it may be that the idea of primogeniture was far too arbitrary for Akbar's rational mind.

So it came down to this: one of his sons would have to prove himself better than the others, more deserving of the throne. Over the generations, the result of this policy is 'best summed up', writes Faruqui, 'by the terse Persian phrase: *ya takht, ya takhta* (either throne or funeral bier)'.[4] For Akbar and his immediate descendants, it caused immense dysfunction and heartbreak.

Akbar, who loved so much to work with his hands, had been his whole life a potter at the wheel, creating a mould for Hindustan – of administrative coherence amidst ethnic and religious diversity – that would survive for centuries. But no man can mould his own children; none of his sons were as he wanted them to be.

So much so, in fact, that Akbar began to look beyond them. 'There can be no doubt,' writes Faruqui, 'that Akbar was working to make the next succession a more competitive one.'[5] The emperor 'loved grandchildren more than sons', according to Abul Fazl, and he was particularly fond of Salim's eldest boy, Khusro.[6] It was to Khusro, one of the most intriguing and tragic characters in the Mughal annals, that Akbar gave a high mansab when he was still a child, a decision 'fully intended to under-cut Salim'.[7]

The emperor had forgotten, however, that he was not the sole arbiter of the future of his dynasty. There was also his harem. It had long been customary for elder Mughal women to maintain an equilibrium between warring brothers and sons. Hindal's mother had once ticked off her son for not